MIŻIEN Claim Check 148 · Climate and energy

Did Malta cut emissions most in Q1 2025?

Testing a Eurostat statement on quarterly greenhouse-gas emissions against Eurostat's revised data

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

"The largest reductions in greenhouse gases were estimated for Malta (-6.2%)."

Eurostat, news item, 14 August 2025.
First estimate of Q1 2025 emissions, same quarter of 2024 as base.

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

Accurate at release; later revised, and one quarter is not a trend

Version 1.0 · 2 November 2026
Status: no right of reply needed
Prepared from public sources and Eurostat data.
Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT
Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

On 14 August 2025 Eurostat published its first estimate of EU greenhouse-gas emissions for the first quarter of 2025. It wrote: **“The largest reductions in greenhouse gases were estimated for Malta (-6.2%), Finland (-4.4%) and Denmark (-4.3%).”** We checked that wording against the news item itself and against Eurostat’s current quarterly dataset. The statement is an accurate account of the August 2025 estimate. In the data as revised since, Malta’s fall is 5.0% and ranks second, behind Finland (10.1%); and the quarter says little about the trend, because Malta’s emissions rose in the other three quarters of 2025.

1. **Eurostat said it, in these words.** The news item of 14 August 2025 names Malta first (−6.2%), reports an EU rise of 3.4% to 900 million tonnes CO_2-eq, and counts 20 countries up and 7 down [1].
2. **The estimate has since been revised.** The current dataset gives Malta -5.0% and Finland -10.1%, so Malta now ranks 2nd of 27 [2]. The EU rise is now +4.2% (903.7 Mt). The 20-up, 7-down split is unchanged.
3. **One quarter is not a trend.** Summing four quarters, Malta’s 2025 emissions were +1.0% on 2024 (EU +1.0%); the next three quarters were up 1.1%, 5.5% and 1.6%, and Q1 2026 is +4.2% [2].
4. **The base was unusually high.** Malta’s Q1 2025 level (1.53 Mt) is still 87% above Q1 2023 (0.82 Mt) in this series; the 2025 fall followed a large 2024 rise. We did not investigate the cause.
5. **Verdict: largely supported (moderate confidence).** As a report of what Eurostat estimated, accurate. The caveats are the later revision and what one quarter can show.



−6.2%
Malta, Q1 2025 on Q1 2024, Eurostat’s Aug 2025 estimate (largest fall)

-5.0%
Malta in the current dataset (2nd of 27, behind Finland -10.1%)

+1.0%
Malta, full-year 2025 on 2024 (sum of four quarters)

+4.2%
Malta, Q1 2026 on Q1 2025 (latest quarter)

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP
A later Eurostat vintage restoring Malta to first place at about −6%, or showing the August 2025 figures were not revised.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN
Eurostat’s published vintage history (not retrievable by us) showing the August 2025 ranking was not what Eurostat itself reported, or a Maltese revision that removes the Q1 2025 fall.

IN THIS REPORT

1 The claim and what we could verify
2 Method
3 What Eurostat published and what the data show now
4 Where the evidence points different ways
5 Testing the claim
6 Verdict and requests for evidence
7 Limitations

1 The claim and what we could verify

The claim record locates this statement through MaltaDaily (19 August 2025) [3], whose headline says Malta "tops" EU reductions and which also quotes the Minister for the Environment. The speaker we rate is Eurostat; the Minister's comment and the headline are not rated. We read Eurostat's own news item [1], which carries the wording below.

What was said	Who	Access
"The largest reductions in greenhouse gases were estimated for Malta (-6.2%), Finland (-4.4%) and Denmark (-4.3%)."	Eurostat news item, 14 Aug 2025 [1]	Read in full
"…a 3.4% increase compared with the same quarter of 2024 (871 million tonnes of CO2-eq)"; EU emissions "estimated at 900 million tonnes"	Eurostat [1]	Read in full
"…increases in greenhouse gas emissions were estimated for 20 EU countries, while decreases were estimated for the remaining 7 countries."	Eurostat [1]	Read in full

SCOPE NOTE

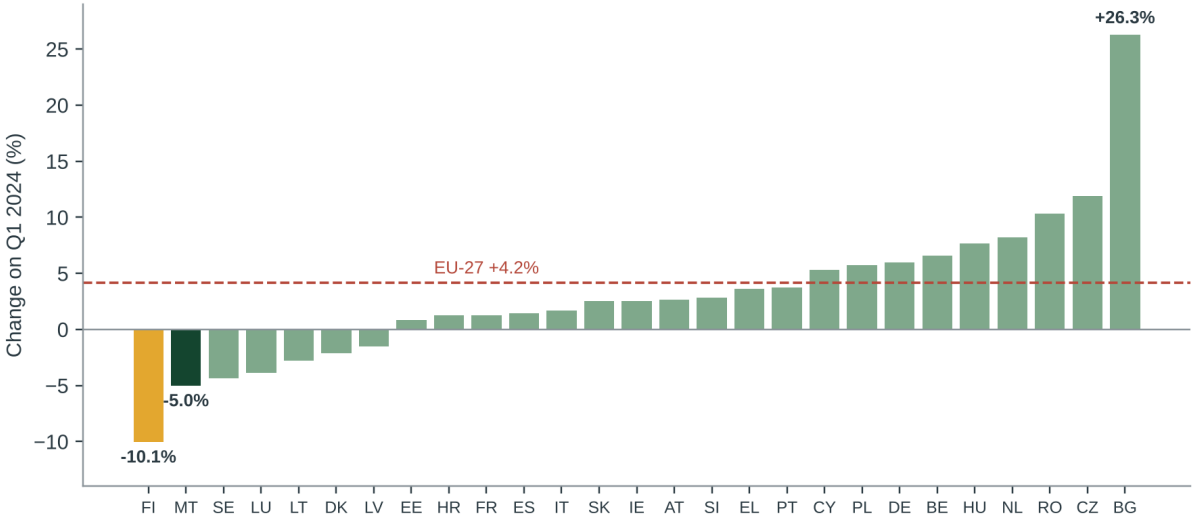
The claim record's phrase "sharpest drop" is MaltaDaily's; Eurostat's wording is "largest reductions", and every figure is an *estimate* (Eurostat, non-seasonally adjusted, same quarter of the previous year). Eurostat's measure counts international aviation and shipping in each country's total, which differs from United Nations reporting rules [1]. This check does not assess Malta's climate policy.

2 Method

Question. Was the statement an accurate report of Eurostat's estimate, and does the quarterly dataset as it stands today still support it?

Evidence. The news item [1] and Eurostat's quarterly air-emissions accounts for greenhouse gases (*env_ac_aigg_q*, non-seasonally adjusted, thousand tonnes CO_2-eq) for all 27 Member States and the EU [2], downloaded on 2 November 2026 (dataset last updated 14 August 2026). All figures are recomputed by *tools/cc-148-report/calc.py* from *data/cc-148/q_all_nsa.json*; results are in *data/cc-148/checks.csv*. We could not retrieve the dataset as it stood in August 2025, so we cannot say which revision moved Malta's and Finland's figures. **Grades:** official statistics are grade C. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What Eurostat published and what the data show now



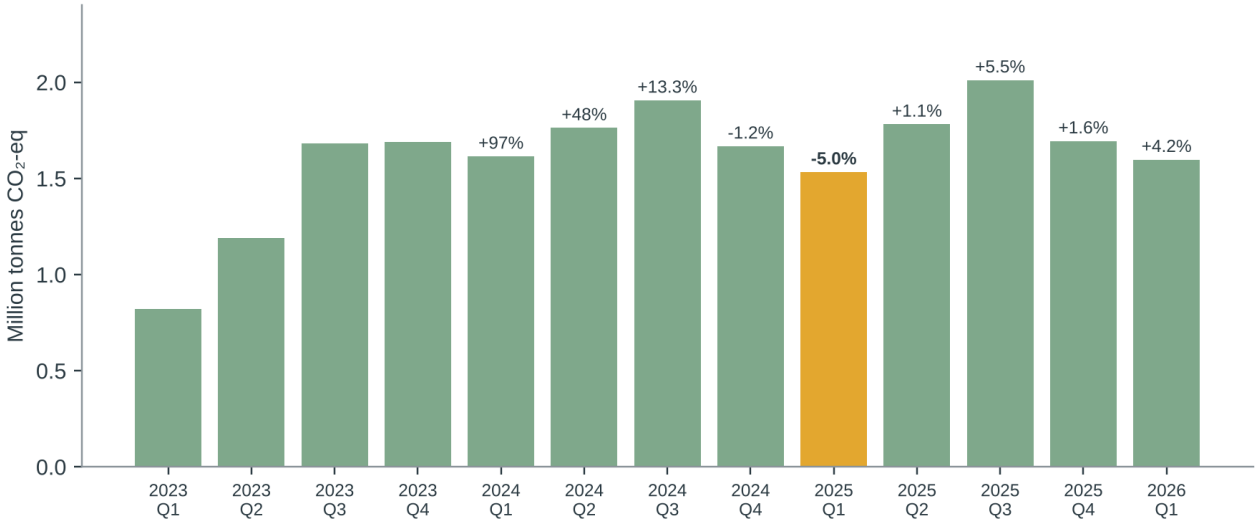
Eurostat env_ac_aigg_q, non-seasonally adjusted, current vintage (updated 14 Aug 2026; retrieved 2 Nov 2026). Eurostat's Aug 2025 estimate was Malta −6.2%, Finland −4.4%.

Figure 1. Change in greenhouse-gas emissions, Q1 2025 on Q1 2024, in the current dataset. Malta (-5.0%) is second behind Finland (-10.1%). Seven Member States fell and 20 rose, as Eurostat reported in August 2025.

Quantity	Eurostat news item, 14 Aug 2025 [1]	Current dataset [2]	Grade
Malta, Q1 2025 on Q1 2024	**−6.2%**	**-5.0%** (1.614 → 1.533 Mt)	C
Finland	−4.4%	-10.1%	C
Denmark	−4.3%	-2.1%	C
Malta's rank for the largest fall	1st	2nd	C
EU emissions, Q1 2025	900 Mt, +3.4%	903.7 Mt, +4.2%	C
Member States up / down	20 / 7	20 / 7	C

Values in data/cc-148/checks.csv. The news item's figures were read from the item; current-dataset figures are recomputed from the downloaded file. Every quarterly value in the dataset carries Eurostat flag "i".

Malta across the year



Eurostat env_ac_aigg_q, Malta, all activities plus households, NSA (retrieved 2 Nov 2026). Labels: change on same quarter a year earlier. 2026-Q1 is the latest quarter.

Figure 2. Malta's quarterly emissions, with the change on the same quarter a year earlier. Only Q4 2024 (−1.3%) and Q1 2025 (−5.0%, highlighted) are falls on the year before.

Over the full years, Malta's four-quarter total was 5.38 Mt in 2023, 6.95 Mt in 2024 (+29.1%) and 7.02 Mt in 2025 (+1.0%); the EU's changed -1.1% and +1.0% [2]. Malta's emissions in this series therefore rose strongly in 2024 and were roughly flat in 2025, with the Q1 fall offset later in the year. We did not investigate why the 2024 level is so much higher than 2023; the dataset gives no reason.

4 Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Did Malta have the largest fall in Q1 2025?

TRUE AT RELEASE; NOT NOW

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

Eurostat's news item names Malta first at −6.2% [1]. A reader checking the statement against the release finds it exact.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

The current dataset gives Malta -5.0% and Finland -10.1% [2], so Malta is second. Eurostat's methodology note says the figures are estimates [1], so later revision is possible.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: an accurate report of an early estimate; the ranking did not survive revision. The size of Malta's fall is also smaller (−5.0%).

Q2 Does a one-quarter fall say anything about the trend?

VERY LITTLE

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

Malta's emissions fell year on year in Q1 2025 while its economy grew [1], and the fall is still present in the current dataset [2].

EVIDENCE AGAINST

The next three quarters rose year on year, the full year was +1.0%, and Q1 2026 is +4.2% [2]. The Q1 2025 level is far above Q1 2023. One quarter, compared with a year-earlier quarter that was itself unusually high, is a weak basis for "tops the EU".

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: Eurostat did not claim a trend. MaltaDaily's headline ("tops EU reductions") and any use of the figure as evidence of progress go beyond the news item; they are not rated here.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim (Eurostat's wording)	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Malta's emissions fell, estimated −6.2% in Q1 2025 on Q1 2024	Matches the news item [1]. Current data: -5.0% [2].	LARGELY SUPPORTED
B. This was the largest reduction among EU countries	Largest in the August 2025 estimate [1]; second behind Finland (-10.1%) in the current data [2].	REVISED
C. EU emissions rose 3.4% to about 900 Mt CO_2-eq	Matches the news item [1]; now +4.2%, 903.7 Mt [2].	LARGELY SUPPORTED
D. Increases in 20 countries, decreases in 7	Matches the news item [1] and the current data (20 up, 7 down) [2].	SUPPORTED

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

An accurate report of Eurostat's estimate; Malta's rank and figure were later revised, and one quarter is not a trend. Confidence: moderate.

Why. (1) Every figure in the statement is in Eurostat's own news item [1]. (2) The 20-up, 7-down split and the existence of a Maltese fall hold in the current data [2]. (3) The ranking (first) and the size (−6.2%) do not: the current dataset has Malta at −5.0% and second. That is a caveat to a statement of an early estimate, not a reversal, which our scale calls *Largely supported*. Confidence is moderate because we could not retrieve the August 2025 vintage and so cannot say what moved the figures.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say that Malta's emissions are falling: over 2025 as a whole they were flat (+1.0%) and Q1 2026 is up 4.2%. Other checks look at annual emissions (CC-026, CC-146).

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ Eurostat's record of earlier vintages of env_ac_aigg_q, to show when and why Malta's and Finland's Q1 2025 figures changed.
- ☐ An explanation, from the National Statistics Office or Eurostat, of the step up in Malta's quarterly series between 2023 and 2024.

7 Limitations

- We could not retrieve the dataset as it stood in August 2025; revisions are described only by comparing the news item with today's data.
- Quarterly figures are Eurostat estimates, not national inventories; they include international aviation and shipping, which weigh heavily in a small island economy, and differ from United Nations reporting [1].
- Annual totals are sums of the four non-seasonally adjusted quarters in the dataset, not Eurostat's annual accounts.
- We did not test sectors (electricity, aviation, shipping) behind Malta's quarterly movements.
- The Minister's reported comment and MaltaDaily's headline are not rated.

References

[1] Eurostat (14 Aug 2025). EU economy greenhouse gas emissions: +3.4% in Q1 2025. News article. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/web/products-eurostat-news/w/ddn-20250814-1

[2] Eurostat. Air emissions accounts for greenhouse gases by NACE Rev. 2 activity – quarterly data (env_ac_aigg_q); downloaded 2 Nov 2026, dataset updated 14 Aug 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/env_ac_aigg_q

[3] MaltaDaily (19 Aug 2025). Malta tops EU greenhouse gas emission reduction charts in first quarter of 2025. Locates the claim; not evidence. https://maltadaily.mt/articles/malta-tops-eu-greenhouse-gas-emission-reductions-charts-in-first-quarter-of-2025

[4] Miżien. Data and calculations: data/cc-148/; tools/cc-148-report/calc.py.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate**: evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low**: evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ◆ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline,** with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it,** and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify,** and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2 Nov 2026	First issue. No right of reply needed (verdict Largely supported).